



Red lechwe

Kobus leche

This medium-sized antelope seldom moves far from water. In the rainy season, the red lechwe often feeds in the water, grazing on plants breaching the surface. If its shallow swampy habitat is heavily flooded, it will retreat to higher ground as it waits for the water to recede. When the water levels drop further in the dry season, the red lechwe is forced out again to forage on land. However, it has to drink regularly in hot weather and always stays within running distance of water.

Water crossing

The water is the red lechwe's primary defense. The lechwe has long, flattened hooves which provide a firm footing on the soft waterlogged ground, and it runs with a bounding gait that carries it over the shallow water. Although this way of running makes it ungainly on land, it is very effective for crossing shallow water quickly to escape attack from predators such as lions, African wild dogs, spotted hyenas, and leopards. The females and young tend to stay closer to the water than the usually solitary males.

Red lechwes breed during the rainy season between December and May. At this point, each mature male takes up a breeding territory, or lek. Male lechwes mature at five years or older, but females do so at 18 months, and so outnumber the mature males. Driven into the center of the lek—sometimes by harassing, immature males—where the dominant males hold court, the females are safe from attack as predators target the males left at the edge. Calves are born eight months later, toward the end of the dry season.

85 percent of the wild population **lives in the Okavango Delta**

